Augustine and the Christian Self

Augustine between Antiquity and the Middle Ages

In many respects, Saint Augustine is a pivotal figure in the history of Western culture. He is one of the most important theologians in the Christian tradition and a bridge between classical antiquity and medieval Europe, with its Christian emphasis. A professor of rhetoric and a scholar, he was highly educated and intelligent, yet wrestled with formidable spiritual problems throughout his life. He eventually became a bishop and was later recognized as a Doctor of the Catholic Church, one of the leading religious thinkers in Western history.

His story is both human and moving. He began as a sinner remarkable for his transgressions, or at least remarkable in his own estimation. After spiritual searching and intellectual work directed toward religious insight, he converted to Christianity. The story of his life leading to that conversion forms the substance of the Confessions, one of the most important texts in the Western tradition.

In reflecting on his life and on what it means to be a Christian in this world, Augustine developed conceptions of God, the soul, and free will. He created a framework into which other Christians could place their own experience. What he formulated was not merely the narrative of one life, but something like an algebraic formula for Christian lives generally. Within the Christian conception of original sin, everyone begins as a sinner. Those who receive God's grace, undergo conversion, and adhere to God's law have the possibility of salvation. Augustine begins as a sinner, but so does everyone else.

Christian autobiography also characteristically includes conversion: a turning point, a radical change in the conduct of life. The Christian understanding of the self begins with an acknowledgment of human depravity and moves, through God's grace, toward a decision to forsake worldly concerns. The believer takes seriously Christ's declaration, “My kingdom is not of this world,” and pursues the kingdom of God beyond worldly affairs. After conversion, spiritual concerns become central. Augustine established milestones along this journey that would become recurring features of Christian autobiography.

Augustine is important as a Doctor of the Church who addressed the intellectual problems of his time. Yet his account also offers insight into Christian life across different periods. He abandoned sinful worldly habits, read the Bible, and applied himself seriously, but in his own understanding these actions did not cause his conversion. Conversion was the product of God's freely given, unearned grace. Grace transformed his orientation toward the world, his understanding of philosophy, and his sense of himself. He became a new man.

His movement from the sinful secular world of classical antiquity, through intermediate positions such as Manichaeism, toward Christian faith is both his own story and, in his interpretation, the story of every Christian. In this sense, he wrote an oddly impersonal autobiography. Autobiography ordinarily attracts us through the distinctive circumstances of an individual life. Augustine offered the opposite emphasis: what mattered was not the particular sins he committed or the circumstances of conversion, but the path a Christian pilgrim must take from this world toward heaven.

Augustine lived from 354 to 430, during the decline of the Roman Empire. Born in North Africa, he spent much of his life there, but also taught rhetoric in Rome and became a professor of rhetoric in Milan. He was cosmopolitan and had access to major texts and thinkers of his day. He sought a spiritual path initially for himself; later, the path he developed would shape the lives of many Western Christians. His arguments against doctrines rejected by the Church helped consolidate Catholic teaching during a period of political and moral upheaval.

Manichaeism and the Problem of Evil

Two positions Augustine opposed were Manichaeism and Pelagianism. Manichaeism attracted him before his conversion; his dispute with Pelagianism arose later in his Christian life. Manichaeism seemed to offer an intuitive solution to one of Christianity's most difficult problems: the problem of evil. The Book of Job addresses this problem, as does the idea of a final judgment, when God separates the sheep from the goats. In this world, people's moral worth often does not correspond to what happens to them. Bad things happen to good people, and good things happen to bad people. If God is just and omnipotent, how can this lack of correspondence be explained?

Manichaeism was founded by Mani, a third-century religious teacher who died in prison under persecution. His followers regarded his death as martyrdom. Before his death, he spread his teachings widely. By Augustine's time, in the late fourth and early fifth centuries, they circulated throughout the Mediterranean world. Manichaeism explained good and evil through two opposing principles, light and darkness. The history of the world of space and time was understood as a conflict between these powers. The influence of darkness could explain why undeserved suffering or undeserved good fortune occurred.

A rough Christian analogy would be to imagine Satan elevated from the status of a fallen angel to a power comparable to God. This is an analogy rather than an exact description of Manichaean doctrine. Its attraction is apparent: if something bad happens to someone who deserves good, the evil power provides an explanation.

From the perspective of a Christian believer, however, this explanation creates difficulties. If the evil power is independent of the good God, it seems to be equally ultimate, and the account abandons monotheism. If the evil power was created by God, the old question returns: why did God create it? Either the explanation introduces a second ultimate power or it fails to solve the problem of evil. Augustine struggled with these questions for years. Between the beginning of his philosophical search at about nineteen and his conversion shortly before his thirty-second birthday, he gradually moved away from Manichaeism.

His criticisms became influential in the Church's rejection of Manichaean teaching. This is one reason he occupies a pivotal place in Western religion and thought. Particularly important was his argument about moral responsibility. If an evil power as strong as the good God causes the evil we do, then we are no longer responsible for it. A person could claim that theft or murder was not a choice but the action of a puppet controlled by an evil power. This would remove moral responsibility and undermine the moral structure of Christianity.

Augustine therefore argued that Manichaeism led to moral fatalism, the opposite of the Christian demand for responsibility. His arguments contributed to its loss of intellectual authority in the late Roman world. He also attacked astrology, which was associated

with Manichaean belief. Around the year 400, astrology was treated as intellectually serious and had to be addressed by serious thinkers, however quaint that may seem today. Augustine often examined such questions through something resembling Socratic dialogue with like-minded friends.

One argument concerned two children born at the same time. A friend explained that, when his mother gave birth to him, an enslaved woman in the household also gave birth. Yet the two children experienced very different lives. Their simultaneous births did not produce matching destinies. Augustine treated this as a decisive objection to the claim that the stars determined human fate. He recorded the argument, which weakened astrology's intellectual credibility and further undermined the Manichaean position.

Pelagianism, Original Sin, and Grace

Before becoming a Christian, Augustine was drawn to Manichaeism because it appeared to solve the problem of evil. When he found it inadequate, his spiritual search continued. Later, as a Christian bishop, he opposed another position: Pelagianism. In the contrast drawn here, it represents the opposite moral tendency. Associated with the ascetic teacher Pelagius, it offers an optimistic account of the human ability to live a Christian life. Through discipline, attention to Scripture, and proper moral conduct, a believer can progress toward salvation.

In Augustine's criticism, this becomes a doctrine of works rather than dependence on God's incomprehensible grace. By reading Scripture, directing the soul toward spiritual matters, and longing for conversion, the believer appears able to achieve not only conversion but sanctity. It is a perfectionist doctrine. Its appeal lies in the apparently reliable path it offers: apply yourself diligently, and move toward holiness. This resembles a tradition of moral self-perfection associated with Athens being grafted onto the religious tradition associated with Jerusalem.

Augustine's own experience had convinced him that effort was insufficient. He had tried to discipline himself and force himself into a Christian pattern of life, but neither intellectual nor moral work could produce grace. Effort increased his anxiety over the absence of conversion and his despair about his sinful condition. Grace, for Augustine, came through God's intervention in the believer's soul. His objection was that Pelagianism made grace appear superfluous, as though human beings could produce salvation for themselves.

Against this optimism, Augustine emphasized original sin. Human beings are intrinsically sinful and marked by disordered desire; they belong to this world and require a transformation that does not originate in themselves. The claim that one can reach God solely through one's own effort appears too Greek, too Promethean. From Augustine's perspective, the idea of saving ourselves contains an element of arrogance and hubris.

He sought a position between two unacceptable alternatives. He rejected Manichaeism because of its moral fatalism and Pelagianism because its moral perfectionism neglected original sin. Through the concepts of grace and original sin, he formulated characteristic categories of Western theology. They enabled him to retain moral freedom and responsibility while also insisting on God's necessary, astonishing grace. This helped define the theological territory of mainstream Western Christianity.

Conscience, Freedom, and Providence

Augustine also helped define the boundaries of the Christian self. He identified the proper domain of the psyche, the ego, or the soul. People are responsible for their conduct and, insofar as possible, for their thoughts and temptations. He emphasized the believer's inner life: intentions and attitudes matter independently of outward actions. We bear responsibility not only for evil acts but also for evil intentions. This is the domain of conscience.

The boundaries of conscience became more precisely articulated over centuries. Augustine was a major figure in that development, explaining what people are and are not responsible for. Conversion and the gift of grace are not under human control; a person cannot manufacture them. Evil conduct, however, cannot be blamed on an external evil power. We retain responsibility for the sins we choose to commit. These distinctions demarcate the Christian self and the domain of free will.

Remarkably, Augustine developed this account within a providential theory of history, especially in the City of God, one of his major works. God exists outside time and is not limited by space. From the creation of the world, every event within time is known to God. What has happened and what will happen are already present to divine knowledge. From God's perspective, the outcome is known; from the human perspective, the moral struggle must still be fought every day.

We are therefore responsible and free within the overall domain of divine providence. This seems paradoxical, and Augustine worked extensively on the problem of reconciling philosophy and theology. Complete reconciliation may not be available to human understanding. Nevertheless, providence and moral freedom can be approached on two levels: the perspective of human beings and the perfect, final perspective of God. Divine knowledge and human responsibility belong to these different perspectives. God can comprehend their relation; we still have practical moral tasks to perform in our own lives.

The Confessions and the Journey toward the Word

The Confessions was written approximately between 397 and 401. It recounts Augustine's journey toward the Word and is remarkable for several reasons. It is a foundational work of Western autobiography. Earlier works such as Plutarch's biographies described the lives of Greeks and Romans, but were not written by the people whose lives they narrated. Augustine chose to tell his own story, yet his purpose was not merely to attract readers through distinctive personal incidents.

He narrated his life to show a path from original sin toward sanctification and grace. No reader could complete that journey without God's help, but Augustine could warn against errors that might impede the pilgrimage every Christian must undertake. He could direct a person toward grace without supplying grace himself. That remained a matter between the individual and God.

Words fascinated Augustine. As a professor of rhetoric, he worked professionally with them, but the first book of the Confessions traces this fascination back to infancy. He describes learning connections between sounds and things in the world. This is not necessarily remembered experience; it may be reconstructed from observation, including observation of his son. The account describes a movement from isolation

toward communication: by uttering sounds, a child can make an inward experience public, bringing the inside into the outside world.

This early fascination with words leads toward his later career, but also toward the Word with a capital W. Ordinary words become the first uncertain steps toward divine truth. This is the goal, the purpose, or telos of Augustine's existence. The repeated attention to speech throughout the book is therefore not accidental. A person gradually acquires words until he can read and hear the Word. The opening of John's Gospel provides the governing expression: “In the beginning was the Word.”

Ordinary words point toward the divine Word. The Confessions describes that movement, which gives Augustine's life its meaning. We are not simply reading the life of a rhetorician or philosopher. He seeks to show a path for spiritual seekers who ultimately find rest in God's Word.

In constructing this Christian self, Augustine also laid foundations for the Middle Ages and its characteristic understanding of the world. He was writing around the year 400. The Romans had already lost the Battle of Adrianople to the Goths, and in 410 Alaric would sack Rome. The decline of the Roman Empire was a process, not a single event, and that process was already underway.

Against this background, Augustine altered the classical conception of the self as an image of virtue, exemplified by Plato, Aristotle, or the great-souled person of Aristotle's Ethics. In this interpretation, he moved away from those ideals as the classical world was ending. This fitted the eschatological elements of Christianity: the old secular world, figured as Babylon, would give way to a world oriented toward Jerusalem, the holy city. He supplied a Christian conception of the self to replace an aristocratic ideal containing pagan and secular elements. His account helped establish standards for understanding an ego, a self, or a cogito, with philosophical implications that continue into the present.

The Structure of the Confessions

The Confessions contains thirteen books. Its unusual form may tempt readers to regard it as poorly organized, and its number of books has sometimes invited speculation about human imperfection. Near the end of his life, Augustine reread his published works. In commenting on the Confessions, he distinguished the first ten books, concerned with himself, from the last three, concerned with Scripture. Within certain limits, that distinction is accurate.

There are two broad ways of interpreting the structure. One emphasizes the first ten books. Augustine narrates his life through the conversion in Book VIII; in Book IX, his mother dies, having prayed for him throughout his life. Book X examines his present spiritual condition. On this reading, the remaining three books may seem like an extended appendix, offering interpretation of the opening of Genesis after the main personal story has reached its climax.

The alternative interpretation developed here treats the final three books as the culmination of his life rather than an appendix. Augustine has longed for communion with God and searched for a path through spiritual confusion. He knows he has received illumination when he can read Scripture and allow it to shape his life directly. The destination of his journey is the ability to read the Word.

If the book concerns ordinary words leading, through God's grace, toward the divine Word, three concluding books of biblical interpretation are appropriate. The number

three also has Christian symbolic significance. These books no longer narrate outward events, but they do narrate the characteristic concerns of his soul. After the first ten books bring us to his present life, we enter the timeless, sacred realm of Scripture. The journey has reached its destination, the holy city. This interpretation gives the concluding books a coherent place in the whole work.

Language, Sin, and the Stolen Pears

The details of Augustine's life form a framework for understanding other Christian lives. Book I concerns words, providence, and early childhood. His account of language would later become important to Ludwig Wittgenstein, who opens the Philosophical Investigations with a passage from the Confessions and critically examines the picture of language it suggests. Augustine's direct examination of lived experience remains philosophically important, even when his theological framework belongs to an earlier age.

Book II turns to sin, one of Augustine's recurring concerns. He is convinced of his own sinfulness, though a reader need not share his estimate of its severity. His presentation may seem to magnify his early importance as a sinner. His actions are hardly comparable to the crimes of Stalin or Pol Pot, yet his language can make his wrongdoing appear extraordinarily grave.

Much of the latter part of Book II concerns stolen pears. As an adolescent in bad company, Augustine joined others in stealing them. We might regard this as youthful foolishness: wrong, certainly, but not the greatest imaginable depravity. For Augustine, however, it revealed a deeper problem. He did not need the pears and did not truly desire them. Nor did his association with the other boys express Christian love. The attraction lay in wrongdoing itself.

Transgression can have its own appeal, particularly to adolescents. Augustine treated that attractiveness as evidence of the wickedness within human beings. The significance lies not in the pears but in the inclination to do evil. This, in his argument, is why an optimistic doctrine of self-perfection fails. Human beings are born sinful and need God's grace as a free gift. Later, Luther, an Augustinian friar, would draw on this emphasis: salvation depends on faith and grace, not on producing it through one's own works.

A serious pursuit of righteousness directs the believer toward grace, but cannot guarantee its reception. The point of the pear story is therefore neither the fruit nor merely the theft. Honest reflection on our own lives may reveal that we have transgressed not simply under external pressure but because we wanted to, finding wrongdoing attractive. Augustine's argument can be paraphrased as follows: “I found wickedness attractive, and so do you.” Once the reader recognizes that affinity, Augustine presents God's grace as the way out of the predicament.

Ambrose and the Interpretation of Scripture

Books III to V describe Augustine's struggle with Manichaeism, a dualistic religion with affinities to Gnostic traditions that seemed to explain evil but ultimately proved unsatisfactory to him. His gradual intellectual progress can be compared with the spiritual journey of Pilgrim's Progress. Although the Confessions uses real personal names, it also describes a pilgrimage of the soul from this world toward the next through

God's grace. For Augustine, part of that movement involved intellectual struggle against Manichaean ideas.

At the end of Book V, Augustine moves to Milan and encounters Bishop Ambrose, a leading theologian and an important figure in Catholic history. Ambrose introduced him to allegorical and symbolic interpretation of Scripture. This mattered because Augustine's classical education in rhetoric and Greek and Roman literature had initially led him to look down on the Bible as an inferior work.

Reading only literally, he saw stories of loaves and fishes as merely stories about bread and fish. He read parables without recognizing their symbolic meaning and found little spiritual value in them. To him, Scripture seemed to be an ancient collection of Near Eastern myths. Ambrose, himself a scholar and distinguished speaker, opened another field of interpretation. Augustine could now recognize what had previously escaped him, and this changed his understanding of Scripture.

Yet conversion was not simply an intellectual problem. By the end of Book VII, Augustine understood objections to Manichaeism and could appreciate symbolic and allegorical interpretation. His intellect was convinced, but he could not make the corresponding spiritual commitment. Religion, in this account, is not merely Platonism or a question of reasoning. It concerns the heart and the soul, and the soul includes more than the ability to reason.

Conversion and Unreserved Commitment

Book VIII movingly describes his resulting despair. Augustine presents himself as inwardly divided, unable to bring his life into agreement with what he intellectually accepted. The Gospel image of a house divided against itself helps express this condition. He paced, wept, and made agitated gestures. His emotional and spiritual life had not yet followed his intellectual judgment. He experienced this as a division within the soul.

In this distressed state, he heard a child's voice. He could not tell whether it belonged to a boy or a girl. It repeatedly said, “Take up and read.” He interpreted this as a divine instruction. He picked up the book nearest to him, which at this point in his life was a volume of the apostle Paul's writings. He opened it and read Romans 13:13–14.

The passage enjoins the reader to abandon drunkenness, lust, quarrels, and jealousy, to put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and to cease providing for the desires of the flesh. Augustine experienced it as God's intervention, freeing him from the snares of sin and bodily desire. In this interpretation, the event is analogous to Paul's conversion on the road to Damascus: the scales fall from his eyes, and he becomes able to relinquish his former way of life.

Sexual desire had been a powerful obstacle to his commitment. His longtime companion had already been sent away before this conversion, and he had subsequently entered another relationship. His earlier reluctance is captured in the famous prayer, “Give me chastity and continence, but not yet.” Many people can recognize that desire to change while postponing the change. The transition from Book VII to Book VIII marks the point when he no longer asks for delay. He wants moral renewal and the acceptance of God without reservation.

When he resolves not to spend his life in drunkenness, lust, or rivalry, and instead to put on the Lord Jesus Christ, he accepts religious faith without conditions. This unreserved

acceptance marks his conversion. Faith demands everything, not merely a portion of life or the soul. The seeker cannot offer a limited commitment as though making a bargain with God.

The Gospel story of the rich young man illustrates the point. In a paraphrase of the exchange, he asks Jesus what he must do to attain eternal life. Jesus directs him to obey the commandments. The young man says he has observed them and asks what is still lacking. Jesus tells him to sell his possessions, give to the poor, and follow him. The young man does not want a demand so complete; he had hoped for something less radical.

On the interpretation offered here, religious faith demands everything a person can give. Augustine was finally willing to stake everything, and he understood the transformation that followed as the reception of God's grace. This changed his life and led him to seek baptism. Ambrose baptized him at Easter in 387. He later lived in a monastic community for several years. His learning, intellectual ability, and piety contributed to his becoming a bishop and one of the Church's leading theologians.

Monica, the Church, and the Closing Books

The conversion occurs in Book VIII of the thirteen-book Confessions. Book IX describes his baptism and the death of his mother, Monica, who is venerated as a saint in the Catholic Church. A believing Christian, she had spent years trying to bring her son into the faith. Her husband had also converted. She died knowing that Augustine had entered the Church and believing that her prayers had been answered.

In the interpretation developed here, Monica's purpose, her telos, is bound up with prayer and its fulfillment. The account emphasizes God's mysterious action and the power of faithful prayer. It is not a doctrine of earning salvation through works. Rather, it shows divine mercy and generosity granted to Monica before her death: she is allowed to see her son become a Christian.

Monica can also be read as a personification of the Church. When Augustine loses his earthly mother, he gains a mother that does not die: Mother Church. He moves from a mother within space and time toward a spiritual mother. In this sense, his maternal connection is not entirely lost. If his mother's prayers have mattered, the prayers of the whole Church appear still more powerful. Reconciliation with the Church also reconciles him with his mother before her death. Her death, and the transfer of his allegiance from family to Church, mark an ending to the narrative of his earlier life.

The final books remain important because they show that he has learned to read the Word toward which his life has been directed. Reading Scripture becomes the source of his reflections on time and eternity. The concluding books concern Genesis, especially God's creation of the world and the command, “Let there be light.” Genesis can be read allegorically as the re-creation of the world within the soul of every believer who undergoes conversion.

On this reading, creation is repeated in the believer's soul. Augustine's interpretation of Genesis shows how divine illumination may enter the soul and what path the Christian must follow from this world toward the next. Genesis happens anew in believers' lives. It is therefore appropriate that the Confessions should end neither with Augustine's own death nor with his mother's death, but with a rebirth into the eternal truth of Scripture.